



▲ Prof S.V. Raghavan inaugurates the FOSSConf'09



▲ Principal Dr V Abhaikumar gives the inaugural address



▲ Demo stalls



▲ Volunteers prepare charts for display



▲ Valedictory function at the K.S. Auditorium, TCE



▲ Participants at demo stalls

common social good.

Writing code is the first and foremost way of participating, and speakers dispensed a fair amount of advice on how that is best done. But they also took time to point out the many other ways to help, most of which do not require programming skills. These range from reporting bugs, writing documentation, translations and localisation, creating artworks, and helping to maintain the infrastructure needed by free software projects.

Localisation was highlighted as an area in constant need of work. India has a long list of languages to translate into, and Indians are the only ones who are well positioned to get that work done.

Day 1

The first day covered topics like freeing geographical information, WLANs and open source software, virtualisation, bioinformatics (from the point of view of open source), kernel module programming, Real-time Linux, open text books, open desktops, BioPuppy (a minimal Linux application for bioinformatics) and GlassFish.

Day 2

On the second day, those who attended the FOSSconf got a chance to listen to the talks on Ruby on Rails, open source in data integration, how FOSS could help you parallelise your programs, an introduction to the RHCE Linux Web, the Apache set-up and configuration, open electronics labs, *Badam Halwa* of Embedded Systems, C under Linux, job opportunities in open source, LTSP (the Linux thin client), building and using a custom C library, Magneto (an e-commerce CMS), how to create and implement a patch, etc.

Day 3

The third day featured sessions on Perl for beginners, GNU/

Linux network tools, network hacking the open source way, Eclipse—a programmer's weapon, software requirements and design specifications, Valgrind, free software, shell scripting, open source vs open systems, etc. The valedictory function was presided over by the principal, TCE, who distributed prizes for the Best Speaker, the Best Project and the Best Demo Stall.

The official website of the conference was *fossconf.in* and as soon as registration opened on it, there was an overwhelming response to register for talks, projects and demo stalls. All the 30 selected projects were developed in FOSS, published on the website and were ready for distribution too. The slides of the 35 speakers have been made available on the website.

No entry fee was collected for the conference. FOSSConf'09 was organised and conducted entirely by FOSS community volunteers. The event was completely non-commercial in nature. Around 1,500 visitors attended the conference over the three days. The organisers had taken the utmost care to make this conference highly beneficial to the participants and a perfect place for knowledge sharing.

Speakers, delegates and visitors benefited from this cooperative development model and hence proved FOSS, otherwise called 'Society responsible software', a successful methodology and a part of a movement. For more details visit glugot.tce.edu or join the mailing list, which is the best place to ask about things related to the event lists.tce.edu/mailman/listinfo/glugot.



By: Dr S. Mercy Shalinie

The author heads the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Thiagarajar College of Engineering, Madurai. She can be reached at shalinie@tce.edu